

05

Email and Calendar Problems

Outlook, mailbox access, send and receive failures, shared mailboxes, calendar issues

Default priority: P3 Medium
(P2 if a whole team or executive is affected)

Target response / resolution: Respond in 15 min / resolve in 2 business hours

Handled by: Tier 1, then Tier 2 / messaging team

Scope

Use this instruction for problems sending, receiving, or accessing email, and for calendar and mailbox configuration issues.

Related instructions: WI-10 Security Incidents, WI-11 Mobile Devices, WI-12 Video Conferencing

Common symptoms

- Cannot send or receive messages, or messages stuck in Outbox
- Outlook shows "Disconnected" or keeps asking for a password
- Mailbox full, or shared mailbox missing
- Meeting invites not appearing, or calendar not syncing

Information to collect

- Email address affected and any bounce-back (NDR) text
- Whether the problem occurs in Outlook desktop, web, or mobile
- Time of the last successful send or receive
- Whether the issue affects one user, a group, or everyone

Resolution steps

- 1 Scope the problem.** Check the service health dashboard first. If the platform is degraded, link the ticket to the major incident and update the user.
- 2 Test in webmail.** Ask the user to sign in to Outlook on the web. If it works there, the fault is with the desktop client or profile. If it fails, the fault is with the account or mailbox.
- 3 Check the account and mailbox.** Verify the licence, mailbox size and quota, sign-in status, and any mail flow rules, forwarding, or blocked-sender entries.
- 4 Fix the client.** Restart Outlook in safe mode, clear cached credentials, run the Office repair, or create a new Outlook profile. Re-add the mailbox if it is a shared mailbox.
- 5 Read the bounce message.** For delivery failures, read the NDR code. Common causes are a mistyped address, recipient mailbox full, message too large, or a blocked domain. Check the message trace for details.
- 6 Check for spam and quarantine.** If messages are missing, check the junk folder and the admin quarantine. Release safe messages and add the sender to the allow list if approved.
- 7 Confirm resolution.** Ask the user to send and receive a test message and check that the calendar shows correct meetings.

Escalate when

- Suspected account compromise, unexpected forwarding rules, or phishing campaign (see WI-10)
- Mail flow problems affecting multiple users or external delivery
- Mailbox corruption, or a restore request for deleted items beyond retention

Resolution and closure

- Record the cause and fix, and add a knowledge article if the issue recurs
- Close after the user confirms mail and calendar work normally

Quick troubleshooting reference

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
Emails stuck in the Outbox	Large attachment, offline mode, or damaged profile	Check Work Offline is off, remove or shrink the attachment, and send again. Rebuild the profile if it repeats.
Outlook keeps asking for a password	Credentials changed, or cached credentials out of date	Clear stored credentials, sign in again, and check MFA status.
Bounce message when emailing one person	Wrong address, mailbox full, or recipient blocks the sender	Read the error code and check the message trace. Confirm the address with the user.
Shared mailbox is missing	Permission removed or auto-mapping not applied	Check permissions and re-add the mailbox manually.
Calendar invites do not appear	Delegate rules, sync lag, or filter on the inbox	Check rules, delegate settings, and the calendar sync status in webmail.

Suggested wording for the user

Open	<i>"Can you tell me if you can see your mail in the web version? That helps me work out where the problem is."</i>
During	<i>"I can see a message trace for that email. I am checking why it did not arrive."</i>
Close	<i>"Your email is working again. Please send me a test message and tell me if anything is still missing."</i>

Good practice

Do

- Check the service health page first
- Use the web version to separate client from account problems
- Read the exact bounce code
- Check for rules and forwarding on repeat issues

Do not

- Do not delete the profile before checking for local data and archives
- Do not release quarantined mail without checking the sender
- Do not ignore unknown forwarding rules
- Do not promise delivery times for external recipients

Worked example

An account manager says a customer never received an important quote.

Ticket note field	Entry
Issue reported	Quote email not received by an external customer.
Checks performed	Message trace shows delivered to the customer's domain. Customer's gateway quarantined it.
Cause	Message held by the recipient's spam filter.
Action taken	Shared the trace with the user so they could contact the customer's IT. Resent a link instead of the attachment.
Result	Customer received the quote and confirmed.

Frequently asked questions

Q. Should we ever release a quarantined message at the user's request?

Only after checking the sender, subject, and attachments. Suspicious messages go to the Security team instead of being released.

Q. How long are deleted emails recoverable?

It depends on the retention settings. Check the Recoverable Items folder first, then the mailbox recovery tool. Record the retention period in the knowledge base for quick answers.

Q. A shared mailbox does not appear in Outlook. Is it deleted?

Usually not. Check the user's permissions, then add the mailbox manually. Auto-mapping can take time to apply after a permission change.

Analyst checklist

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|--|--|
| ☐ Scope the problem | ☐ Check for spam and quarantine |
| ☐ Test in webmail | ☐ Confirm resolution |
| ☐ Check the account and mailbox | ☐ Ticket note completed using the standard template |
| ☐ Fix the client | ☐ User confirmed the issue is resolved |
| ☐ Read the bounce message | |

Preventing repeat tickets

- Warn users about large attachments and suggest sharing links
- Review mailbox sizes monthly
- Keep Outlook updated
- Train users to report suspicious email using the report button